



Bedlam: The fourth Ashes Test in Melbourne was done and dusted inside two days, the pitch taking centre stage as 36 wickets tumbled in a frenetic contest. REUTERS

to put the pressure back on the bowler with a booming shot. It may end up as a swish and miss outside the off stump or a scoop and oops, both harmlessly gone to the wicketkeeper, but boy oh boy, the batter has shown intent and is looking to make a statement, is he not? That is the modern way.

Today, with central contracts and the risible word called 'workload', hardly any international players play any First-Class cricket. He is constantly playing the white-ball format, where he cannot afford to play dot balls, and his bat speed is fast and furious, as that format is all about maximums and fours.

He is mentally conditioned to do that, so suddenly, when he is thrown into the red-ball format, he is at sea the moment the ball does something. The red ball does more in a couple of overs than the white ball does in a couple of games, and then he has little or no experience of how to deal with that.

He thinks counter-attack is the answer, when a little bit of patience, with some deep breaths taken to slow down the adrenaline, might help in reducing the bat speed and the big swing, so even if he miscues or edges, the ball may not carry to the fielder. But then, if he hardly plays

any First-Class cricket, how will he mentally get used to adjusting to the required rhythm of a Test match?

It is not easy at all. Yes, on a pitch where the ball is not moving or turning, he will still score big because that is what he is used to with the white ball. So, should the international schedule be tweaked in such a way that international players play First-Class cricket and get prepared for Test cricket? England's win, even though it came in the fourth Test with the series already lost, does prove once again that the more you play, the better you will get, especially in unfamiliar overseas conditions.

The point, therefore, is whether England should have played a few more First-Class games before the first Test? The 'ares' do not agree with the 'has-beens' here.

The irony is that if it is a pitch where not too many wickets fall but plenty of runs are scored, then the match referee more often than not gives it a poor rating. So, batters scoring loads of runs is a no-no, but bowlers picking heaps of wickets is okay and the pitch has to be rated good or very good.

Clearly, it is no longer a batters' game but the bowlers'.